Israeli ambassador in Washington. I hoped this would mark a change in Israeli policies and help get the peace process started again.

When the foreign minister of Lebanon visited Washington that spring, I told him I was more determined than ever that the withdrawal of all foreign troops from Lebanon would resume soon, and that until that happened, our marines would remain in Lebanon. He said that it had been his experience with American presidents that they at first seemed willing to tackle the problems of Lebanon, but that they "advanced so far and then retreated." I told him I didn't have a reverse gear.

In late March—thanks in part, I think, to Moshe Arens—Israel began sending conciliatory signals indicating it was willing to withdraw from Lebanon under reasonable terms. We responded positively to the new attitude, and once again the level of my optimism that we would achieve peace in the Middle East began to rise. But we soon learned, tragically, that there were many people in the Middle East who did not want peace—at least not as long as it entailed the acceptance of Israel's right to exist.

On April 18, Nancy and I were awakened before dawn by a telephone call informing me that a terrorist's car bomb had just exploded at our embassy in Beirut, killing scores of Americans and Lebanese employees. Among the dead were five marine guards and other U.S. personnel, including our top CIA research specialist on the Middle East.

Shiite Muslim fundamentalists from Iran—who our intelligence people had recently learned were meddling in the convoluted affairs of Lebanon in order to further the Islamic revolution—took credit for the barbarous act. "Lord forgive me for the hatred I feel for the humans who can do such a cruel but cowardly deed," I wrote that night in my diary.